ENGLISH LANGUAGE & LINGUISTICS 1A

*Language, Power and Society*

University of Glasgow

# Semantics

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Week 7

# Who decides what a word means?

# Is a Jaffa Cake a cake or a biscuit?

- In the UK, cakes are zero-rated for VAT; chocolate-covered biscuits are taxed at the standard rate
- McVitie's argued before a VAT tribunal in 1991 that Jaffa Cakes are cakes
  - A cake goes hard when it is stale; a biscuit goes soft
  - McVitie's baked a giant Jaffa Cake for the tribunal to make the point
- The tribunal agreed: a Jaffa Cake is a cake, and carries no VAT

Association of Taxation Technicians, "VAT treatment of Jaffa Cakes explained"

# Is Subway's bread *bread*?

- Irish VAT law zero-rates bread, defined as containing sugar or fat of no more than 2% of the weight of the flour
- Subway's rolls contained sugar at about 10% of the weight of the flour
- The Irish Supreme Court ruled in 2020 that they are not "bread" for VAT purposes, so they are taxed

*Bookfinders Ltd v The Revenue Commissioners* [2020] IESC 60

# Is a burrito a sandwich?

- Panera Bread's lease at a shopping centre in Massachusetts barred the landlord from renting to another restaurant selling more than 10% sandwiches
- The landlord then rented a unit to Qdoba, which sells burritos, tacos and quesadillas
- Panera went to court, arguing that a burrito is a sandwich

"two thin pieces of bread, usually buttered, with a thin layer (as of meat, cheese, or savory mixture) spread between them"

*Webster's Third New International Dictionary*, s.v. *sandwich*, as cited by the court

# Is a burrito a sandwich?

"A sandwich is not commonly understood to include burritos, tacos, and quesadillas, which are typically made with a single tortilla and stuffed with a choice filling of meat, rice, and beans."

Judge Jeffrey Locke, *White City Shopping Center, LP v PR Restaurants, LLC* (Mass. Super. Ct., 31 October 2006)

# Is a burrito a sandwich? In Indiana, yes

- In 2024 a judge in Indiana ruled the other way
- A planning agreement allowed a restaurant selling made-to-order, Subway-style sandwiches
- A Mexican restaurant applied; the judge held that tacos and burritos are sandwiches

*Quintana v Fort Wayne Plan Commission* (May 2024)

# Can a veggie burger be a *steak*?

- In March 2026, EU negotiators agreed to reserve 31 meat terms for meat products
  - Not allowed on plant-based products: *steak*, *bacon*, *chicken*, *beef*, *pork*
  - Still allowed: *burger*, *sausage*, *nuggets*

Provisional agreement of 5 March 2026 (European Parliament, Council of the EU and European Commission)

# Meaning and power

> “How does one meaning gain dominance over all others? […] those with meaning-making power […] attempt to ‘naturalize’ their own ideologies about the social category a given label denotes.”
>
> Campbell-Kibler et al. (2002: 9)

# The LPA toolbox








# Semantics

Four tools for analysing how a text persuades:

| | |
|---|---|
| **Transitivity** | who does what to whom |
| **Modality** | how certain, or how obliged, something is presented as being |
| **Presupposition** | what a text takes for granted |
| **Semantics** | **which words are chosen to name and describe, and what those words carry with them** |

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# Names and Labels

# Denotation and connotation

- **Denotation**: what a word refers to, and the conditions something must meet to count as one
- **Connotation**: the associations and attitudes a word carries from the ways it is used
- Two words can share a denotation and differ in connotation

*spinster, bachelor, playboy*

*student*

*girlfriend, wife*

# Partners

- *husband, wife*
- *common-law husband, common-law wife*
- *boyfriend, girlfriend*
- *lover*
- *other half*
- *significant other*
- *him indoors, her indoors*
- *cohabitee*
- *bidie-in*
- *partner*
- *situationship*
- *talking stage*

> Which would you put on an official form? Which would you use in front of your gran?

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# Pejoratives and Reclamation

# Pejoratives

- A **pejorative** is a word or expression with negative connotations: *control freak*, *lazy*, *slipshod*, *nerd*, *Karen*




Bill Watterson, *Calvin and Hobbes*

# Reclamation

- **Reclamation**: a group takes over a word used against it and uses it of itself
- *queer* → *Queer Studies*

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# Avoiding Connotations

# Avoiding connotations

Euphemism

Dysphemism

Jargon

Register

Metaphor

# Euphemism

- A **euphemism** is chosen to avoid a word that would be taboo, upsetting, rude or face-threatening

mathematically challenged

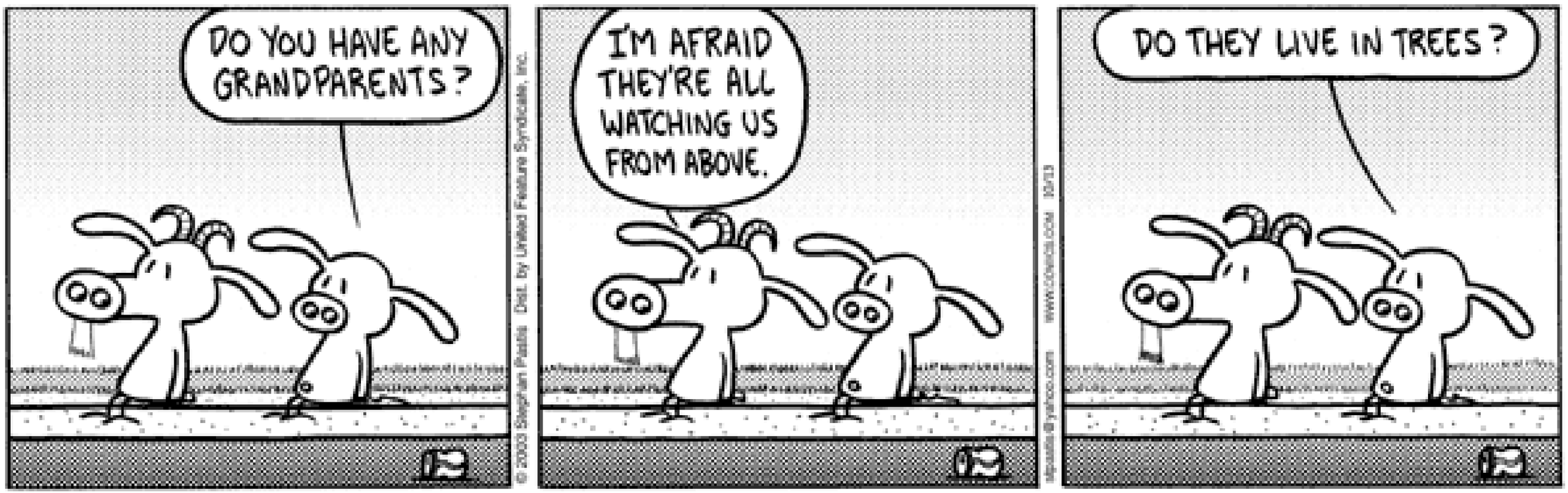
passed away

let go

between jobs

Ange Postecoglou has been “relieved of his duties as head coach with immediate effect”

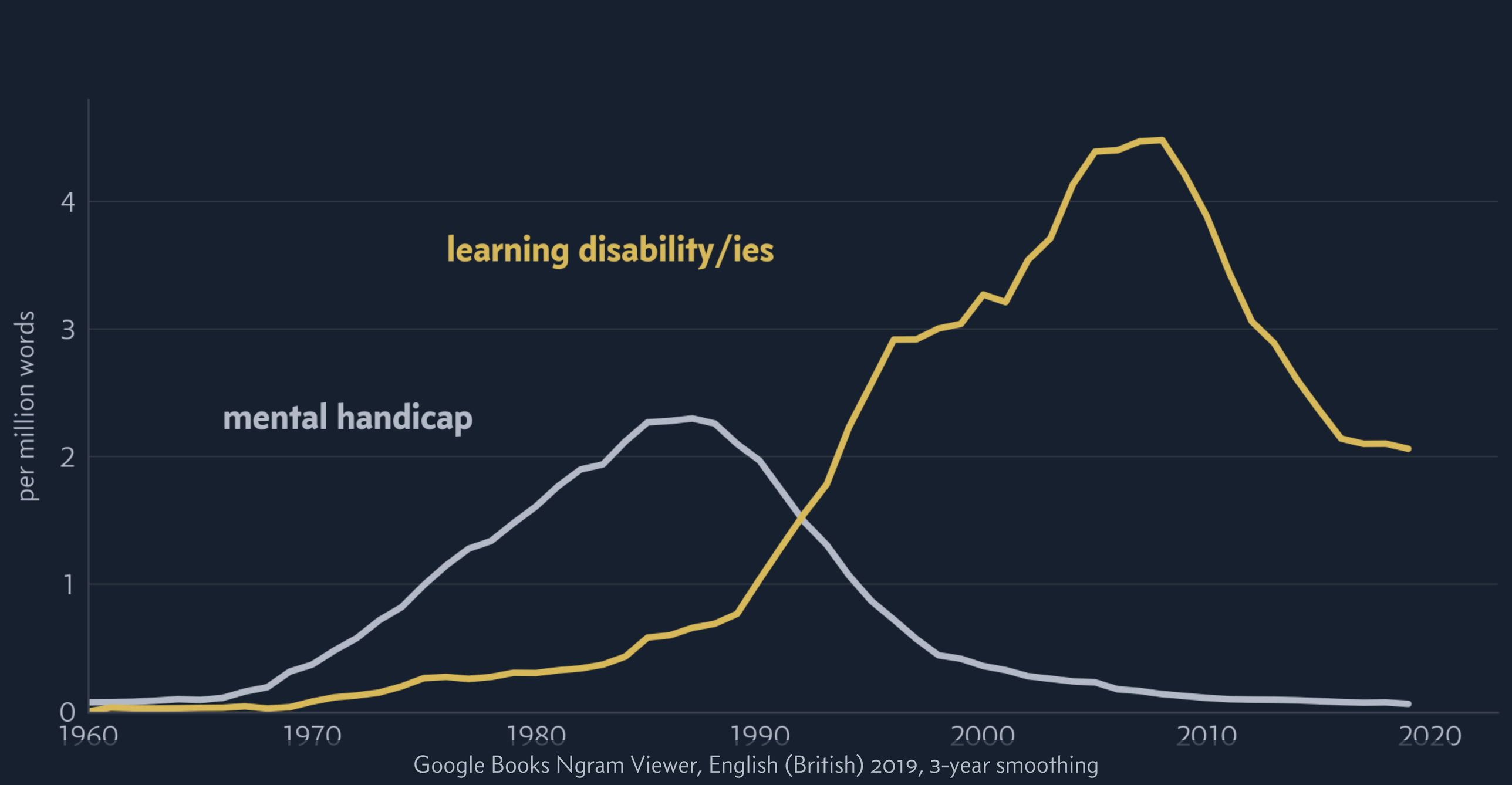
Nottingham Forest’s statement, 18 October 2025, after 39 days in the job




Stephan Pastis, *Pearls Before Swine*

# The euphemism treadmill

- A euphemism picks up the connotations of the thing it names, and in time needs replacing itself
- Pinker (1994) traces *water closet* → *toilet* → *bathroom* → *rest room*




Google Books Ngram Viewer, English (British) 2019, 3-year smoothing

# Dysphemism

- A **dysphemism** is chosen for more negative connotations than the neutral word: to offend, to shock or to amuse

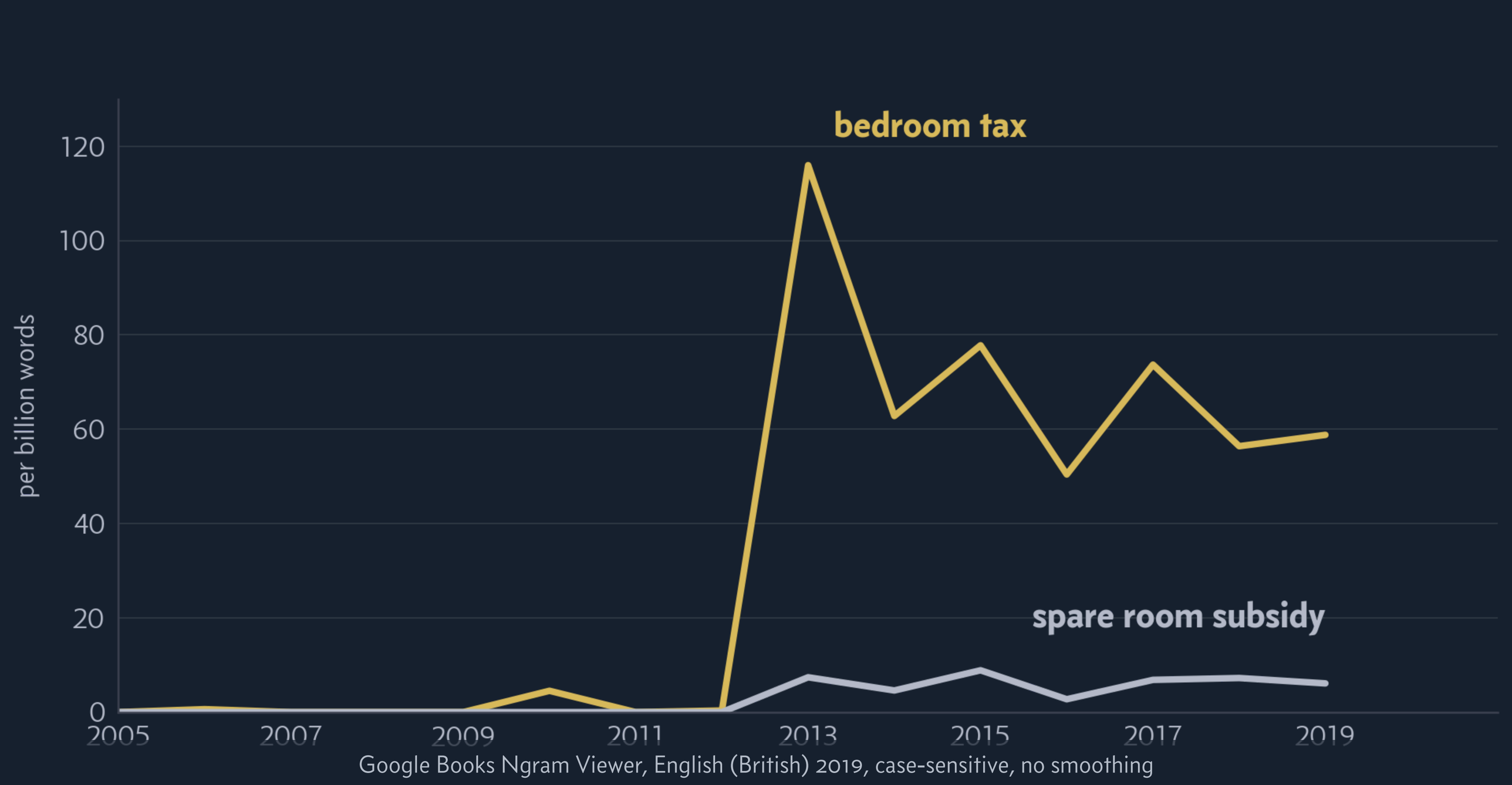
bit the dust

finished off

*clankers* (robots and AI)

# Name the policy, name the tax

| Label | Used by | The policy's own name |
|---|---|---|
| *death tax* (2010) | Conservatives | funding for a National Care Service |
| *bedroom tax* (2013) | Labour and other critics | removal of the spare room subsidy |
| *dementia tax* (2017) | Labour and other critics | the 2017 Conservative manifesto's social care plan |
| *family farm tax* (2024) | Conservatives | changes to agricultural property relief |


bedroom tax
spare room subsidy
per billion words
120
100
80
60
40
20
0
2005
2007
2009
2011
2013
2015
2017
2019
Google Books Ngram Viewer, English (British) 2019, case-sensitive, no smoothing

# Jargon

- **Jargon** is the vocabulary of a profession or other group; to outsiders it can sound grander or more evasive than ordinary words

rodent exterminator

cabin service director

collateral damage

special military operation

# Register

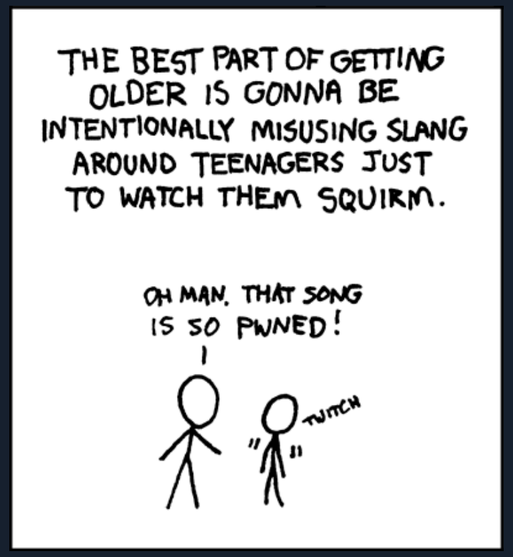
- **Register**: technical, everyday or slang; formal or informal

This phone is fast.

This phone has an octa-core processor and 12 GB of RAM.

This phone is pure rapid, ngl.

# Register




- *67*: Dictionary.com's Word of the Year 2025
- *unc*: on Dictionary.com's 2026 shortlist

Randall Munroe, *xkcd* (CC BY-NC 2.5)

# Metaphor

- A **metaphor** describes one area of experience in terms of another

> DISEASE IS WAR: *fight off an infection, give in to the flu, battle cancer*

- For some people with cancer, war metaphors meant failure; for others, strength (Semino et al. 2017)

# Metaphor

**IDEAS ARE PLANTS**

Communal mentality and shared responsibility are **flourishing** beliefs in many cultures. These ideas are **planted** very early in the minds of children. They are further **cultivated** both in the family and in the social life. Very soon, **deeply rooted** beliefs are **grown**.

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# Stereotype

# Stereotype

- A **stereotype** is a socially constructed ‘typical’ member of a category of people
- Stereotypes become a problem when attitudes or biases are based on them

Successful lawyers earn a lot of money, and after winning a case **he** wants to celebrate in style.

Any secretary you care to name will work hard for **her** pay.

According to disapproving church writers, the Vikings were addicted to drink, gluttony and **women**.

# Stereotype

A father and his son are in a car crash. The father dies at the scene. The son is rushed to hospital, and the surgeon on duty looks at him and says, “I can’t operate on this boy. He’s my son.”

**Who is the surgeon?**

# Most direct to least direct

sacked

fired

let go

parted company by mutual consent

relieved of his duties

> With a neighbour: rank these.

# Next weeks

- Week 8: Language and Politics
- Week 9: Verbal Hygiene

# Reading

- The semantics section of your LPA booklet
- Simpson (1993)
- Optional: Jeffries (2010), chapter 2, “Naming and describing”

# References


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Pinker, Steven. 1994. The game of the name. *The New York Times*, 5 April 1994.

Semino, Elena, Zsófia Demjén, Jane Demmen, Veronika Koller, Sheila Payne, Andrew Hardie & Paul Rayson. 2017. The online use of Violence and Journey metaphors by patients with cancer, as compared with health professionals: A mixed methods study. *BMJ Supportive & Palliative Care* 7(1). 60–66.

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